Uzbekistan Expanded Higher Education. Did Equality of Opportunity Follow?

Evidence from three waves of household survey data, 2010–2023

AUTHOR
Nozimjon Ortiqov

AFFILIATION
Center for Economic Research and Reforms

PUBLISHED
April 1, 2026

SUMMARY

Since 2017, Uzbekistan has rapidly expanded higher education. Enrollment has nearly tripled and the number of institutions has roughly doubled. The question is whether available evidence yet shows a comparable weakening of family-background persistence. Drawing on three waves of the Life in Transition Survey (2010, 2016, 2022-23) covering 3,155 adults aged 25–64, the answer is cautious: not yet. A persistence score measuring how closely children's educational position tracks their parents' rose from 0.134 in 2010 to 0.307 in 2016 and stood at 0.252 in 2022-23. In the latest wave, 87 percent of respondents from university-educated families also attained a degree, while those from less-educated backgrounds were concentrated at upper-secondary level. During COVID-19 school closures, mothers provided 87 percent of reported learning support at home. Urban households fared better than rural ones on several access measures. The evidence points to three priorities: close gaps earlier in the educational pipeline, make tertiary expansion more equitable rather than simply larger, and build a system that tracks whether opportunity is becoming more equal over time.

The expansion is real, but uneven

Since 2017, Uzbekistan has undergone a rapid higher-education expansion. The number of institutions rose from 119 in 2019/20 to 222 by 2024/25, while total enrollment increased from about 441,000 to more than 1.4 million.[1] In principle, larger and more geographically dispersed higher-education capacity can reduce supply-side barriers to entry. But the question that matters for policy is not only whether more students can enter the system. It is whether the expansion is broad enough to weaken the link between family background and educational attainment.

The expansion was not uniform. The national average more than doubled, from 73 to 180 students per 1,000 youth aged 20-24, yet no region outside Tashkent city has caught up with where the capital started. Figure 1 shows the pattern: growth was fastest in regions that began from the lowest enrollment base, but all regions remain far below Tashkent. The reform story is not simply one of growth; it is one of uneven growth across places.

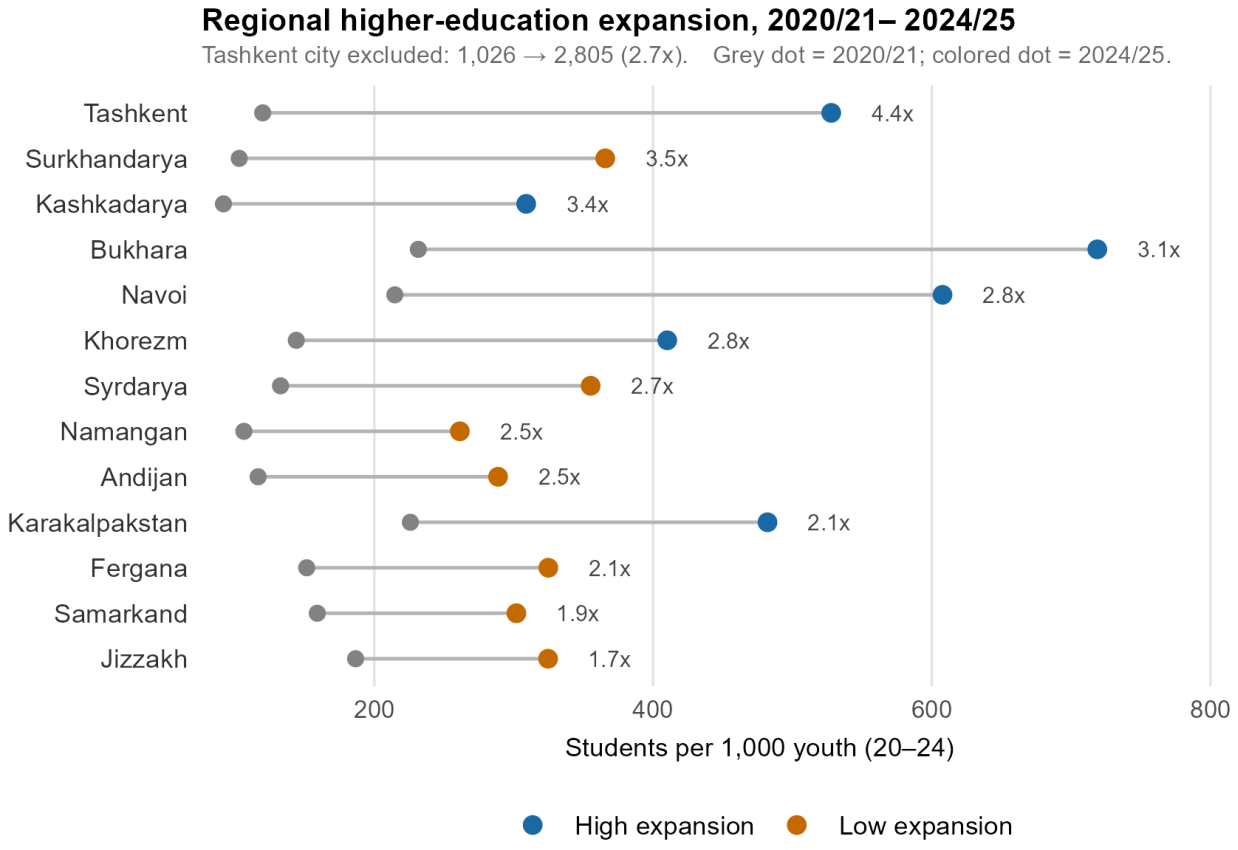

Figure 1: Regional higher-education growth, 2020/21 to 2024/25 (excluding Tashkent city). *Source: Administrative higher-education series. Grey dots show 2020/21 levels; colored dots show 2024/25 levels. Tashkent city is excluded (it grew from ~1,026 to ~2,869 students per 1,000 youth aged 20-24). Regions are colored by expansion intensity.*

How households finance access is also relevant. In high-expansion regions, 26 percent of remittance-receiving households report directing remittances to education, compared with 16 percent in low-expansion regions.[2] Migration income may be helping some households convert expanded supply into actual enrollment. But this does not show that stronger local opportunity has displaced family-resource constraints. Expanded capacity and unequal household means can operate at the same time.

Family background still predicts who gets ahead

Three waves of the Life in Transition Survey allow us to track how closely children's education follows their parents' over time.[3] The preferred cross-wave measure is a persistence score: higher values mean children's educational rank tracks parental rank more closely. That score rose from 0.134 in 2010 to 0.307 in 2016, a statistically significant increase ($p < 0.01$), and stood at 0.252 in 2022-23 (Figure 2). The decline after 2016 is not statistically significant. Part of the low 2010 reading may reflect differences in how parental education was recorded that year, so the 2010-to-2016 increase should be read with some caution.[4] Even so, the central result is stable: family background remains strongly linked to educational attainment.

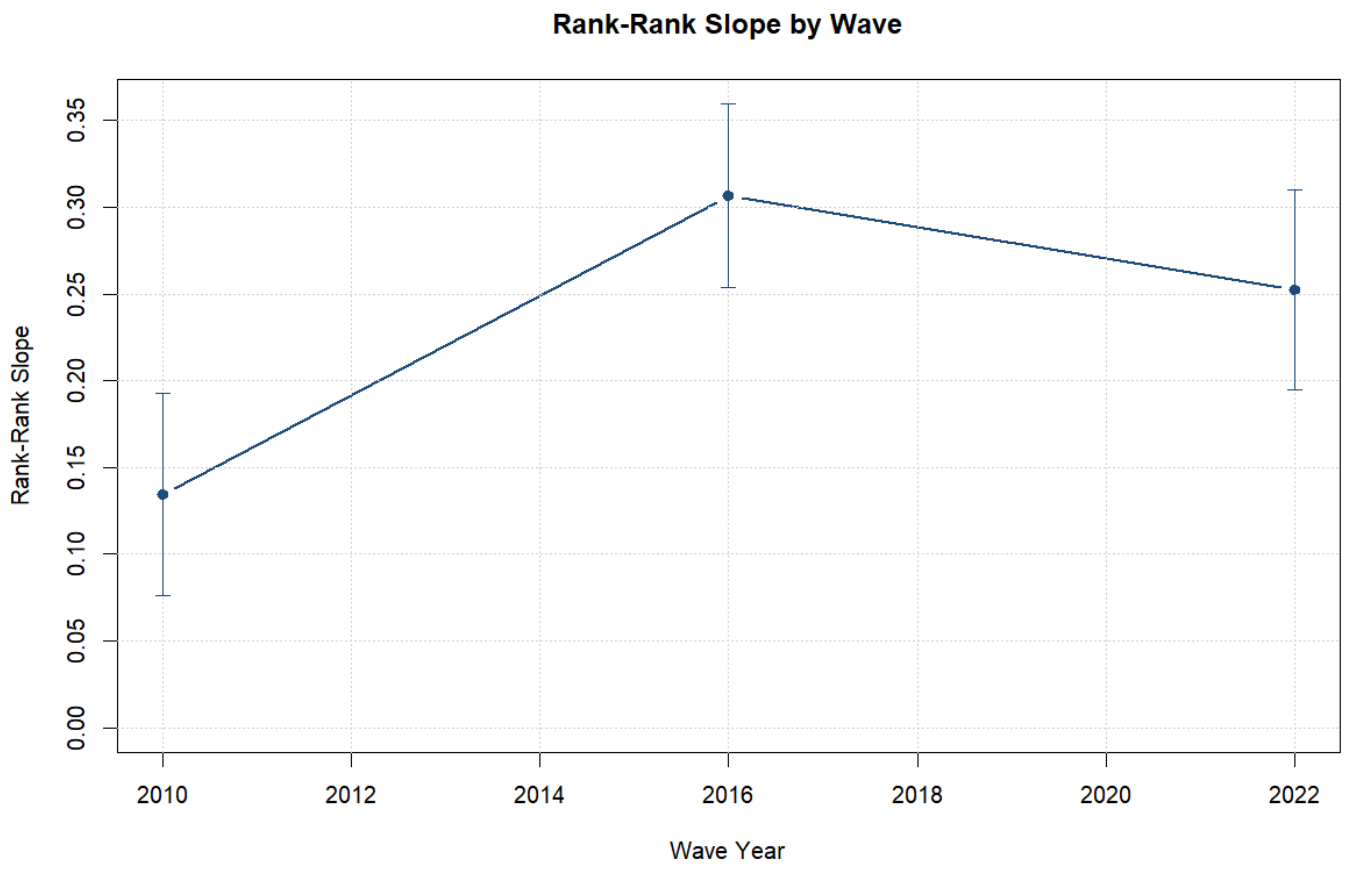

Figure 2: Persistence score across LiTS waves. Higher values mean children's educational position tracks their parents' more closely. *Source: Life in Transition Survey (EBRD), waves II (2010), III (2016), and IV (2022-23). Adults aged 25–64 in Uzbekistan. Shaded band: 95% confidence interval.*

Controlling for region, birth cohort, urban residence, and gender does not change this conclusion. Parental education remains the strongest predictor of attainment in the pooled specifications. Adding migration exposure and household structure barely moves the parental-education coefficient, which means the gradient is not explained away by a small set of observable household characteristics.

Transition data make the inequality visible in concrete terms. In 2022-23, 87 percent of respondents from university-educated families also reached university. Respondents from upper-secondary backgrounds were split more evenly between staying at the same level and moving up. For lower-origin families, the sample is too thin for precise estimates — which is itself revealing about limited access at the bottom of the distribution.

The right conclusion is narrower than "expansion failed." The evidence does not identify the causal effect of specific reforms, and much of the adult attainment observed in 2022-23 was shaped before the most recent surge in tertiary provision. But the available evidence does not yet show a clear weakening in the relationship between parental background and children's attainment. In international comparison, these persistence levels fall in a moderate-to-high range for developing countries, close to Turkey and other middle-income settings where enrollment has grown but family-background gradients have not faded.[5]

Where you live and when you were born still matter

National averages hide meaningful variation. Across all three survey waves, urban residents show higher upward mobility than rural residents.[6] The rural disadvantage does not disappear once we look at migration and remittances. Rural households actually report higher emigrant rates (19 vs. 13 percent) and more remittance receipt (18 vs. 12 percent), yet the educational mobility gap persists. The likely reasons — fewer nearby institutions, weaker local labor-market returns to education, more fragile digital infrastructure — cannot be isolated with the data here, but the pattern is consistent with structural barriers that money transfers alone do not remove.[7]

Age differences are present but should not be overstated. Younger adults (25-34) show a different cross-wave trajectory from older cohorts, with persistence scores that shift more across waves. But in every age group and every wave, family background still predicts educational attainment. No cohort in the data has escaped this pattern.

Regional variation is wide. In 2022-23, the persistence score ranged from near zero in some regions to above 0.4 in Tashkent city. Place still shapes how strongly family background matters.

COVID-19 exposed how unequal learning support can be

The 2022-23 LiTS child module covers a small subsample of roughly 180 households with school-age children, so it should be read as illustrative.[8] Even with that limitation, the disruption it records is large. Seventy-eight percent of households reported that a child's education stopped entirely during school closures. Nearly three in four reported at least one barrier to remote learning: 73 percent cited internet problems and 64 percent lacked adequate devices.

When schooling shifted into the household, mothers provided most reported learning support: 87 percent of cases, compared with 4 percent for fathers. Because mothers bore most of this burden, households' ability to absorb school closures likely depended heavily on maternal time and resources. Families with less schooling also reported more internet and device problems, which suggests that emergency learning conditions reinforced existing inequalities rather than offsetting them.

The lesson extends beyond pandemics. Whenever formal instruction is interrupted — whether by school closures, teacher shortages, transport problems, or weak infrastructure — students from lower-resource families are more exposed. Digital inclusion means more than nominal internet coverage. It requires reliable connections, working devices, and a realistic acknowledgment that not all households can substitute for schools equally.

Household budgets show why expansion alone may not be enough

Household Budget Survey data from 2021-2025 add useful context, though they are not the basis for the intergenerational estimates.[9] About 63 percent of households report positive education spending. Some 14 percent pay for tutoring. Nearly 15 percent receive remittances, and 80 percent have internet access. A meaningful share of educational investment is financed through household-level spending and support strategies as well as public provision.

When admissions expand, better-resourced families are often better placed to respond first. In high-expansion regions, remittance-for-education spending is 10 percentage points above low-expansion regions, while overall education spending shares are nearly identical across the two groups. The safest reading is that expanded supply is interacting with unequal household capacity. New seats can widen formal access without automatically equalizing who is able to use them.

Three priorities for making expansion more equitable

The evidence in this brief is descriptive, not causal. It does not estimate the effect of specific reforms. Even so, it points to three areas where policy can be better matched to the problem the data reveal.

1. Intervene earlier and at predictable risk points. The pattern in the data is consistent with disadvantage accumulating before tertiary entry rather than being resolved there, though this brief does not isolate the exact stage at which gaps widen most. The Ministry of Public Education and regional education departments could focus on three transition points: end of lower secondary, end of upper secondary, and first year of tertiary. Concrete steps include diagnostic assessments tied to remediation at grades 9 and 11, targeted academic support around national exam years, and transition guidance for students from rural and first-generation backgrounds. Rural districts should be prioritized, since that is where low mobility and thin institutional access overlap. A near-term indicator: the share of students from the lowest parental-education quartile who sit for the university entrance exam, tracked by region.

2. Judge tertiary expansion by who enters, stays, and finishes. Additional seats do not address information gaps, weaker preparation, or unfamiliarity with application procedures. The Ministry of Higher Education could require new and branch-campus institutions in high-expansion regions to run structured outreach in secondary schools, paired with need-based grants, rural dormitory and transport support, and preparatory courses in low-access districts. Academic bridge programs and first-year advising should be standard for students whose parents did not attend university. First-year retention should be monitored as a routine metric. Quality assurance and student-support capacity should scale with admissions, especially in regions where institutional growth has been fastest. Success should be measured not by how many students enter, but by how many disadvantaged students enter, persist, and complete a degree.

3. Build a routine equity-monitoring system. Uzbekistan currently has no regular mechanism for tracking whether opportunity is becoming more equal. The State Statistics Committee, in coordination with the Ministry of Higher Education, could construct a dashboard that links administrative records on enrollment, retention, exam participation, and completion with household-survey indicators of parental education, urban-rural residence, first-generation or disadvantaged status, and learning conditions. At minimum, it should report outcomes by region, urban-rural residence, and gender. The LiTS data used here cover only three snapshots over 13 years. A system built on administrative records could provide annual updates and flag disparities as they develop. A concrete first step: publish annual enrollment and completion rates disaggregated by region and gender, which existing administrative data already support.

A note on what this evidence can and cannot show. The analysis documents associations between parental and child education. It does not estimate causal effects of specific reforms. Because most respondents in the LiTS surveys completed their education before the post-2017 expansion, the results establish how strong

family-background persistence is but cannot yet tell us whether the expansion is weakening it. The COVID module covers a small subsample and illustrates patterns rather than proves mechanisms. These are real limitations. But they do not diminish the main result: the link between family background and educational attainment in Uzbekistan is strong, and the expansion confronts a wide gap. Full methods, diagnostics, and robustness tests are reported in the companion research paper and technical appendix.

Footnotes

1. Administrative higher-education series compiled from official sources. Covers all recognized higher education institutions nationwide. ↩
2. Descriptive comparison from the Household Budget Survey (2021–2025), split by regional expansion intensity. High-expansion regions: 26.1% remittance-for-education rate; low-expansion: 16.4%. Overall education spending shares are nearly identical across groups. ↩
3. The Life in Transition Survey (LiTS) is conducted by the EBRD. The 2010 and 2016 waves covered 10 oblasts; 2022-23 expanded to all 14. Analytical sample: 3,155 adults aged 25–64 with non-missing own and parental education. ↩
4. The 2010 LiTS wave recorded parental education in years of schooling rather than categories, and parental-education missingness was higher than in later waves. Sensitivity checks in the companion paper show that the wave ordering of persistence scores is robust to multiple imputation approaches, but the 2010 level carries more uncertainty than the 2016 or 2022-23 estimates. ↩
5. Hertz et al. (2008) place intergenerational education correlations between about 0.20 and 0.60 across countries. See also Narayan et al. (2018) and Aydemir and Yazici (2019). ↩
6. Category-based upward mobility rates by urban/rural residence across all three waves. The urban advantage is descriptive; the rank-based series is the preferred cross-wave benchmark. ↩
7. If educational selectivity of emigration differs by family background, the survey-based persistence estimates may not fully capture mobility patterns among the most mobile families. This applies to all household-survey analyses of countries with high emigration. ↩
8. The child-module subsample covers respondents with a child enrolled before COVID and non-missing parental schooling, about 180 households after exclusions. Results should be read as illustrative, not representative. ↩
9. Household Budget Survey 2021–2025, pooled. Descriptive context only. The parent-child linkage rate in HBS is too low for direct mobility estimation. Full methods are in the companion paper. ↩